

Vertigo

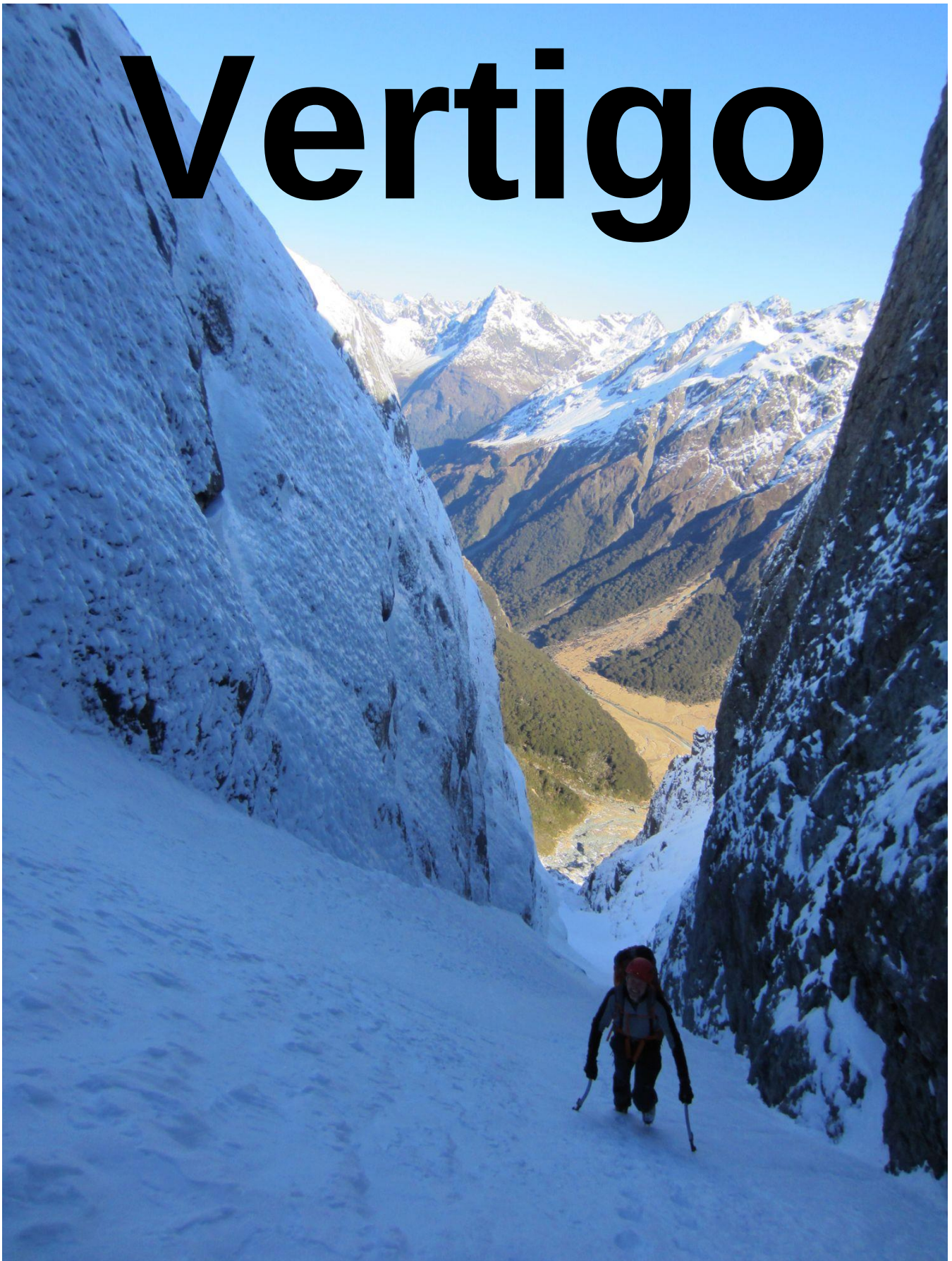


Photo Rob Hawes ascending the Somnus Couloir, Humboldt Mountains (Photo: Simon Bell)

Newsletter of the New Zealand Alpine Club, Wellington Section
www.facebook.com/nzacwellington

Section News

September section night - “Bashing my head against a brick wall”

Paul Hersey will be coming along to the September section night to talk about the fine line between success and failure among the world's greater ranges, focussing mostly on his latest attempt on Anidesha Chuli (White Wave) but also touching on previous trips. Here's a pic from the latest trip of Shelley at Camp Two.



Shelley at Camp 2 – John Price Photography

Section Nights are usually at the Tararua Tramping Club clubrooms, 4 Moncrieff Street, Mount Victoria, Wellington on the second Monday of every month. New and prospective members are welcome. Meetings start 8.00 pm with tea & coffee afterwards

Upcoming Events

Wellington Section Photo Competition

Reminder to all budding photographers that the closing date for the 2014 Wellington section photo competition has been extended to 1 October.

HOW TO TAKE PART

1) Pick out your best pictures for the following categories:

ALPINE ACTIVITY: climbing, skiing, whatever you do up high

ALPINE GENERAL: scenery and views that make you want to come back

ALPINE NATURE: the little gems of beauty along the way

ROCK CLIMBING: hardest moves, slickest lines

PHOTOJOURNALISM: the shot that tells a story

HUMOUR: whatever gets you a laugh

2) Download the entry form [here](#). Complete the form and email it to wgtntsectionphotocomp@gmail.com

If entering slides or prints please scan them first – we need all entries to be in digital format.
Maximum of three entries per category per person – thanks!

For further info, contact Julian Davidson by email at wgtntsectionphotocomp@gmail.com

Trip Reports

Stargazing through a broken window into my aspiring dream

By Simon Bell

A few weeks ago I excitedly opened a package shipped to me from an online gear store. At the bottom of the box I found a free shot of 5-hour energy drink. 'It's quick, simple, and made to help hard working people' that label claimed. Last week I got to put that claim to the test...

Rob Hawes and I had a plan to head into Colin Todd sometime in August to check out the south face of Aspiring and tick off Stargazer (highest peak in the Haast range). An unusually long fine spell was spotted, which started on about the 15th of August and is still holding as I write this on the 27th.

As I carried my gear from Christchurch airport towards my parked car on the 14th I passed some youths of questionable character milling about the Hagley golf course and I immediately thought of my car. Sure enough, while approaching I noticed the fuel cap was open and the back window broken. For the second time, my trick of disengaging the mechanism which allows the lever under the driver's seat to open the car boot has paid off. The car started fine and no fuel was taken. Yes!!

Later that evening I rolled up to Rob's house in Wanaka and we made plans to fly in the next day (15th). I left my car with the Smith and Smith agent to get the window replaced for free. This made me feel a bit better about us dropping \$900 on a helicopter to fly into Bevan Col.

The forecast was for 80km/h southerly winds on the summit of Mt Aspiring when we flew in. This made me somewhat nervous, particularly as the pilot appeared to be rather new to the area, based on the conversations we overheard at the hanger. However, the flight was only a little gusty and without incident.

South face of Aspiring

After we were dropped at Bevan Col on the 15th we put on snow shoes and headed over to Colin Todd Hut. This was to be our home for the next six nights. Unlike my regular home, this one required a shovel to dig out the snow from around the front door and did not have running water. The last entry in the hut book was from Guy McKinnon. He had checked out the snow conditions on the Bonar Glacier before his successful winter ascent of the east face of the Popes Nose in July. His entry mentioned poor snow conditions, deteriorating weather and a 'nasty bivy'!

After a cup of tea we headed outside again to check out conditions on Mt Aspiring. We noted that even though a significant amount of snow had recently fallen (one metre was reported at Cascade Saddle a few days prior), most of this snow had been blown away by strong southerly winds. Snow shoes were useful in the afternoon to travel around the Bonar Glacier, but not essential. The ramp, south west ridge and upper sections of the south face were all wind stripped and the avalanche risk on these aspects was judged to be low. We also noted that

even late in the afternoon the south face was still completely in shade at this time of year. This is a good thing as it means the risk of ice falling due to solar activity is minimised. The light southerly breeze forecast for the following day would also help to keep things cool.

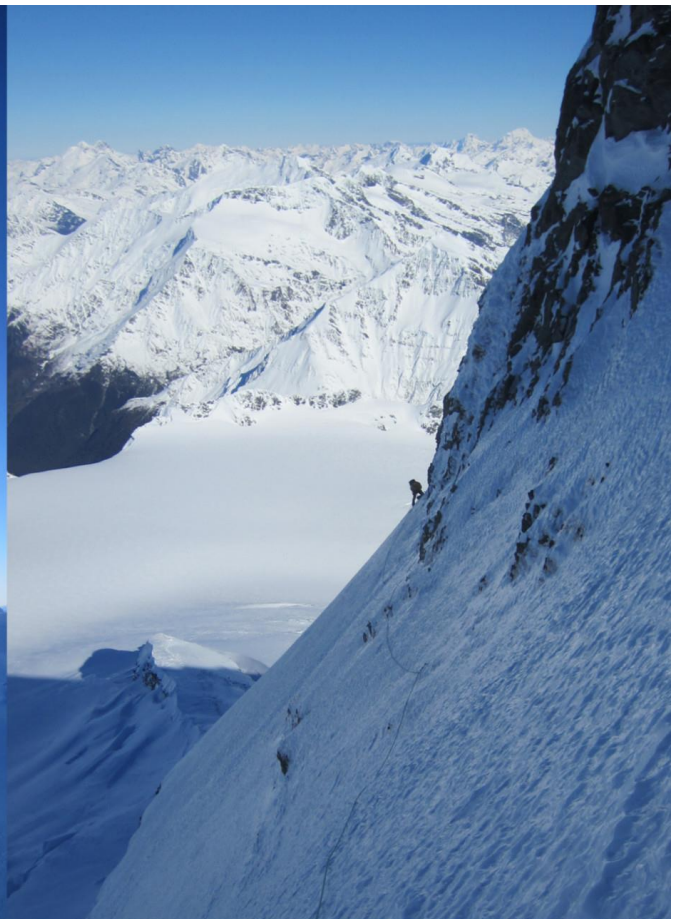
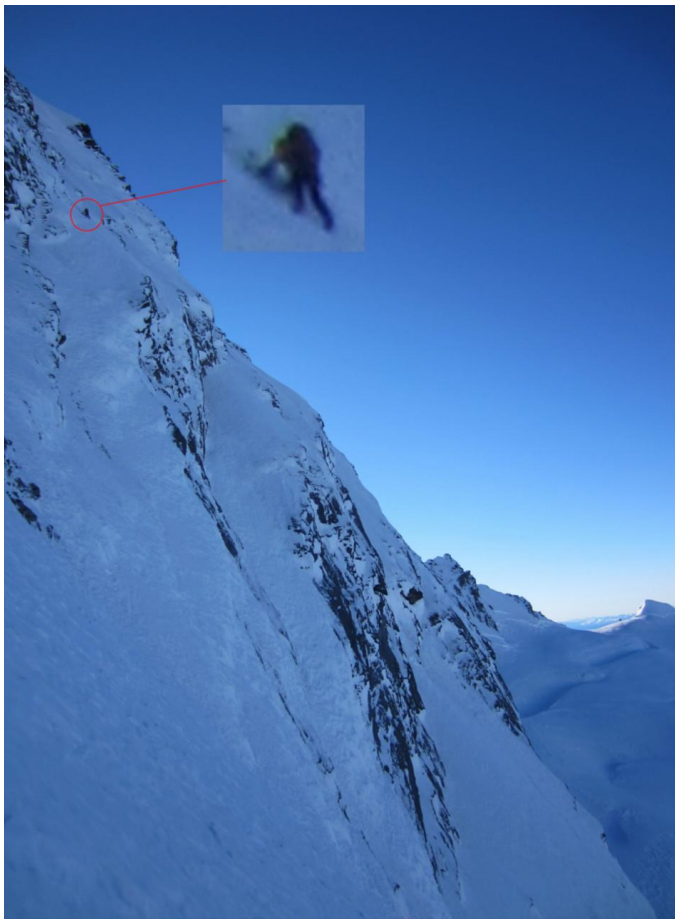


Mt Aspiring with our approximate lines shown (green is the south west ridge and red is the original route on the south face)

On the 16th we departed Colin Todd Hut shortly before 5am and headed to the south face. At about 8am we started weaving our way through the crevasses at the bottom of the face. We were forced out left a long way. This meant that after climbing over the 'schrund we had to traverse back right about 100m on slightly soft snow before reaching the ice proper. We were both glad to reach the ice which turned out to be fantastic 'climbing ice' (i.e. probably not so great for accepting ice screws).

With Rob ahead, we soloed up the first half of the face. The exposure was terrific. However, the climbing was relatively straightforward with each ice tool only requiring a single swing to stick. As we progressed up the slope I thought it was about time to sample the 5-hour energy product and took a swig and scoffed a few lollies. Now I was really in the zone. As I continued up the steep ice slope, Rob went out of sight and I became lost in the moment, focused only on my feet, tool placements and breath.

As I reached the end of the lower section, Rob came back into view and we discovered that the traverse section which looked short from the Bonar Glacier was actually quite long. We started pitching at this stage. I led the first pitch which was a 60m horizontal traverse. Going up is much easier! During the second pitch we probably only gained 20m vertical. Pitch three ended up being the crux pitch and was highly enjoyable to lead. As I belayed Rob up to the top of pitch three I could see that we were getting quite close to topping out on the Coxcomb Ridge. Sure enough, pitch four brought us to the ridge and from here it was a short walk to the summit.



Clockwise from top left: soloing the lower section of the south face, the traverse pitch, abseiling off the buttress on the NW ridge, Simon leading the crux pitch.

We were on the summit about 3pm. It was great to finally get out of the shade and we quickly started to overheat. Just below the summit we stopped for a late lunch and we melted some snow to rehydrate for the descent.

Rob wandered off ahead as I took some more photos and I met him again at the top of the ramp. We discussed our descent options. We knew from the recce day that the ramp was quite icy. It would require pitching, especially given our tired states. We chose to continue along the north west ridge until we reached the end of a large buttress. From here it is possible to rap off using 2 x 60m ropes onto snow slopes above the Bonar Glacier. I hadn't done this before but Rob had seen guides use this as a descent route in summer. The ridge traverse was interesting but not overly challenging and we reached the buttress in about thirty minutes. The abseil went smoothly and we were putting the ropes away as the sun went down. Once back at the hut we decided the following day would be a rest day! Interestingly, my calf muscles were fine, but my quads felt similar to when I did the 50km Tararua peaks loop in a day (sore!)

Stargazer

During our rest day (17th) it lightly snowed. I spent my time reading Paul Hersey's book 'Where The Mountains Throw Their Dice' (found at Colin Todd Hut) which was a very thought provoking book on climbing.

The following day (18th) we headed towards Stargazer, initially staying on the west side of Rolling Pin and subsequent peaks until we got to the col between Mainroyal and Pt 2296. However, within minutes of the sun hitting the eastern slopes, we observed, from the safety of the col, the new powder sloughing off. In some cases these sloughs were initialising small point releases on the main slopes, which would have the potential to knock a climber off their feet. With some disappointment we returned to the hut to try again the following day.

We were successful on the 19th and I'm glad we chose to wait a day as our old tracks were lightly covered in snow in places from the solar-related activity the previous day. The biggest drama was that Rob initially started climbing Skyscraper, not Stargazer! I confirmed my gut feeling with a GPS and we continued onto Stargazer without incident. In the wintry conditions the east ridge was straightforward and did not require a rope (except for glacier travel).



Simon on the summit of Stargazer, Skyscraper in the centre and Mt Aspiring in the background.

South west ridge of Aspiring

That afternoon, with our two main objectives already completed, we managed to contact DOC in Wanaka via the radio and get an updated forecast. 'We don't normally do this' she said, but we were grateful that she did on this occasion. We were a little scared calling her back though after I realised I'd forgotten to record one key bit of info (the situation for tomorrow!)

The forecast was good for climbing the next day (20th) which was coincidentally the date I had said I'd be back at work. Not so! The south west ridge was too tempting.... Also my partner Lorraine had just climbed Kilimanjaro (5895m). Climbing Mt Aspiring (3033m) twice makes 6066m right!?

Having already been past the south west ridge on the way to the south face, and knowing the descent route, we had a rather relaxed approach to this climb. The lower sections of the ridge were pleasant and we rapidly gained height. We also had a prime view of the south face and it looked rather imposing from this angle. We were glad we did the harder climb first!

At this time of year the crux was totally filled in with fat ice and it was an enjoyable lead. We kept pitching past the crux and towards the summit (three pitches in total), mainly because it seemed easier to continue pitching than try to put the rope away.

We summited Mt Aspiring for the second time on this trip at 11am and Rob promptly made a phone call to his daughter. As it turned out, tomorrow was his birthday and he was confirming that we'd be out tomorrow for the celebratory dinner!



Mt Aspiring south west ridge. Rob below crux (left) and Simon leading the crux (right)

Walkout

'Happy birthday!' I called out to Rob after the 4:30am alarm woke us up. Outside it was clear but a strong southerly was blowing. We left the hut around 6am but only made it as far as the toilet before returning! The spindrift stung our faces and we could barely stand. However, we knew the hut was on a windy spot and it probably wouldn't be as bad lower down. We put on sunglasses to protect our eyes from the snow and set out once again!

The trudge across to Bevan Col in high winds was pretty average and we were running on empty. After finding a sheltered place for a drink and an OSM bar we felt a little better and continued on out. The lower sections of the Bevan Col descent route were very straightforward in winter conditions (what slabs? what waterfall?) and we were back in Wanaka before dark, with plenty of time to freshen up before heading out for dinner!

Somnus

During a rest day in Wanaka (22nd) I decided another peak was in order before returning to Wellington. Fortunately, Rob agreed. We set off from Wanaka at around 6am on the 23rd for Somnus, the highest peak in the Humboldt mountain range. We accessed Somnus by driving

to the start of the Routeburn Track, walking to Routeburn Falls Hut and then up the North Branch.

Wikipedia told me that "In Greek mythology Hypnos was the personification of sleep. The Roman equivalent was known as Somnus." What I knew about Somnus was that it has a magnificent feature – the Somnus Couloir. The climb is about 1800m vertical from the carpark to the summit and about one half of this is gained via the couloir. Step plugging up this sucker really started to wear us out, even with light packs (no ropes, just a stove and some overnight camping gear).



Rob below the Somnus Couloir (left) and descending the Couloir (right)

We arrived on the plateau late afternoon and were able to pitch the tent, drop our gear and summit before dinner. A pleasant night's camping followed before a gentle walk out on Sunday 24th. I'd left my car in Frankton for a 'quick' dash back to Christchurch. This ended up taking ages, particularly as every hour or two I'd stop and buy delicacy items such as sushi, real-fruit ice cream, coffee & a muffin, fish and chips, Red Bull and chicken chips! Sunday night was spent in a motor park cabin in Christchurch, before catching the early morning flight back to Wellington and the world of work.

Postscript: Back in Wellington I read there had been a spate of break-ins and car thefts near the Christchurch airport. The police have arrested someone in relation to this. So hopefully the old dunger will be safe again...

Mt Hopeless – smoothly irresistible

By Philippa Yasbek

The Gang of Four hatched the plot the week before when Dan was awarded a leave pass. By the time we met up on Friday night, the trip had grown to two cars and ten people.

We arrived at the Nelson Lakes cooking shelter on Friday night in sub-zero temperatures. While it has walls on three sides, electric lighting and a zip for making hot water bottles, it was still bone-chilling. Puffer jackets were required on the ride across Lake Rotoiti and the walk in was punctuated by the sound of crunching frost. After about four hours tramping, we arrived at Hopeless Hut which was also sub-zero. Fire lighting was interrupted by a brief sighting of the sun, which had everyone lined up outside the toilet catching the rays while finishing off their lunch. The afternoon was spent scouting the bush bash and start of the route.



Richard on the approach with Hopeless in the background (Photo: Sharron Came)

I'd assumed all the emails about the wine and cheese were a piss take but Saturday night saw a bottle of wine, two litres of beer and more blue cheese than anyone could eat. It must have had the right soporific effects because we were all in bed before eight. We had a much warmer night, having squeezed ten people in to a six bunk hut. Brendan and Mike got out the hut first, followed by Lans and me, then the rest of the crew just before four.

We saw Brendan and Mike's headlamps ahead of us after about ten minutes but lost sight of them when we entered the bush. We got out the other side and didn't see them. We hoped they were just faster than us and would re-appear when we got up on to the ridge. We kept getting over little rises in the ridge with no sightings. We discussed their super-human athletic abilities in envious tones. Eventually we spotted their lights out on another line. They'd missed a crucial creek crossing to the cairned route and had continued up an unmarked spur. They

started traversing across to our ridge and we eventually caught up with them just as the patches of snow were getting big enough for crampons. It got progressively colder as we climbed and the pre-dawn wind really picked-up. Brendan and Mike decided the wind was too much and headed back down.

More plodding and we were up in the bowl beneath the summit. We decided to take the route up to the col at the top of the Hopeless Couloir. Unfortunately it was corniced and we couldn't safely get to the top of it. So back down to the bowl. By this time, the rest of the group had made it up and there was a route-finding conference settled by GPS. We'd try the alternative route to the top. At least the wind had died down. The climbing progressively steepened. Some of the party hadn't been on crampons before. Pitching would have taken too long and we were on a tight timeframe to make it back to the ferry. So everyone turned back except for Lans and me. We kept daggering up to the summit. About 20 or 30 metres from the top we came across another set of footprints. Presumably somebody who had climbed over from the Cupola side?



Philippa approaching the summit ridge (Photo: Lans Hansen)

The summit was reached but the sunrise was marred by the cloud that had started appearing in the middle of the night. It was our first grade two climb and our technical tools had actually been useful.



View from the summit – Mt Rotoroa (Photo: Lans Hansen)

We were highly motivated to descend quickly. We needed to get back to the hut to return ropes and gear to the others, before they started their walk out. There was a reasonable amount of controlled sliding down bushy slopes and we arrived just after the others. In a reminder to always stay attentive, one of the others took a spill descending the tussocky spurs – managing to let out three expletives before sliding to a halt with ripped pants and a soon-to-be-colourful bruise.



Descending with the Angelus range in the background (Photo: Sharron Came)

We got slightly strung out on the tramp back with one sprained ankle and some double pack carrying. The highlight of the walk out was encountering two rather large fellows in white gumboots, both of whom were carrying similarly corpulent possums under each arm.



Possums make great pets (Photo: Sharron Came)

I still haven't worked out if the two ferry rides, two water taxi rides, three hours of driving, eight hours of flattish tramping, four hours of uphill slog and two hours of descending were worth it for fifty metres of great climbing. At least the photos look good.

Trip participants: Sharron Came, China Yu, Vincent Zintzen, Daniel Pringle, Richard Bell, Brendan Eckert, Mike Schier, Helen Curtis, Lans Hanson, Philippa Yasbek

2014 Snowcraft Course Report

By Mark Edgecombe

Cast List

Simon Williamson and Dave Eaton:	a pair of Alpine 1 Instructors
Carolyn Ellis, Vincent Zintzen, China Yu, Dan Pringle:	their protégés
Adam Newberry, Leighton Riley, Rebecca Hamblin:	thrill seekers from the metropolis
Nils Toussaint:	an agile and ambitious Frenchman
Jordan Poste:	a Canadian adventurer
David Costello:	an affianced Irishman
Peter Humphries:	diver turned mountaineer
Mary Adams and Kirsten Dale:	two trampers in search of altitude
Ian Barnes, Tim McKenzie, Mark Edgecombe:	young fathers let loose for the weekend

Prologue

The team meets at BP Taihape. Despite the proposed 8.30pm rendez-vous, Adam, Leighton, Becky and Mark don't arrive till 9, through no fault of Leighton's VW Golf station wagon. More to blame is the upturned army truck just north of Bulls and an over-long stay at Levin's Café Anatolia. Simon says to get changed into our warm gears.

Act One: The Tempest

Four kilometres along the road between SH1 and Tukino Lodge, it becomes clear why Simon wants us in our mountain gears. A four wheel drive blocks our progress on a narrow stretch and the NZAC fleet comes to a halt. Many get out into the mountain air, and it's mountain air all right, big gusts of the stuff and spindrift with it, coming across from the south and west. Eventually the jam is cleared and the two wheel drive carpark reached. The Tukino shuttle meets us and it's into the back for the climb to the lodge, the driver burrowing the van into the heart of the mountain. Inside the lodge the fire is on and managers Craig and Sue make the welcomes. Simon has a few words and it's time for bed around midnight. The wind is loud through the wee hours.

Act Two: Now is the winter of our discontent made glorious summer...

Saturday dawns sunny but still windy. Breakfast's at seven and then there's a team session round the fire. It's time to talk weather forecasts and avalanche warnings. The twelve rookies produce bits of folded paper - printouts from avalanche.net and metvuw - from out of packs and pockets. The massive lodge window looks right onto the mountain's eastern face, up towards Te Heuheu; it's like being in the front row at the movies. China points out some markings in the snow: "Crown ridge," he says. Simon says it looks like it could easily avalanche. Dan takes a white board marker and draws a diagram of a crown ridge on the white board for us all to mull over. Come mid-morning it's time for gear distribution: helmets, ice axes, crampons, probes and shovels. We each put on a transceiver and make them beep a bit and

then it's downstairs to fit crampons onto our boots. Outside the lodge we complete transceiver checks and then Simon splits us into two groups.



The next six hours see us cover a decent set of skills: toeing into soft snow; edging into icier snow; how to hold an ice axe; cutting steps; putting on crampons; walking with crampons; climbing and descending with crampons... As the day goes on the wind dies down - either that or we've found ourselves a more sheltered spot. Late afternoon and the two groups are back together, hurling ourselves down a slope so that we can practise our ice axe arrests. Jordan is especially vigorous when it comes to launching himself. Adam quickly looks accomplished. Nils, being Nils, finds an icier slope just further along and starts falling off that instead. "More realistic," Simon says. In fact, Simon is at pains to emphasise that the ice axe arrest is something you want never to use. "Like having a fire extinguisher in your kitchen," he says. "It doesn't mean you want to start lighting fires."

Back at the hut, Tim and Carolyn get dinner started. The wine and cheeses come out and for Nils and Vincent, sheesh, it might as well be Europe. Dave E gives an impromptu lesson on navigation: the main point is to have a "nav-plan" sorted before you even get onto the mountain; you don't want to be calculating bearings and trying to remember which side of north the 23 degrees comes off while high up in a sou'wester. Dave mentions "handrails", the unreliability of man-made features on maps, whiteouts, using rope to measure distances, and a bunch of other tricks from his murky Tararua past. Then it's dinner and videos. Naked skiing at Banff anyone? Or a brisk walk up Antarctica's Ulvetanna Peak? Simon says we might like to try something a bit simpler first.

Act Three: All's well that ends well

Sunday is perfect. Peter gets out at six to take a few photos: Ngauruhoe looks so tranquil, serene. As the day wears on, there are unspoilt views of Tauhara, and over its shoulder even Tarawera is visible ("Doesn't have snow on it; not interested," says China). The Kaimanawas, Kawekas and Ruahines have all taken a dusting, though. We're out on the snow just after eight, with Carolyn doing the transceiver checks, and then it's up to a good bit of slope for some avalanche rescue. Vincent is convincing as a skier whose two brothers, both due to be married the following day, have been buried under snow. Spurred on by the pathos, Becky quickly locates the first and has him out within three minutes. The second proves more difficult to locate. The transceiver has him a metre and a half below the surface, but it turns out he's only just under - but for ten minutes... Simon says we need to be more systematic in our use of the probe.



There's time for some more toe cramponning up a nice steep bit of mountain, a brief lesson on Italian and clutch knots and ice axe anchors, and then it's back to the lodge for lunch, tidy-up and the long drive back to the mundane, low-altitude reality of home and the working week.

Epilogue

We who've gained a taste for snow
and in some cases, even ice,
would like to let our clubmates know
that invitations would be nice
to come with you on expeditions
up Ruapehu, Taranaki -

anywhere with snow-conditions!
Homai, then, te pakipaki,
for our team of teaching guns -
Carolyn, Vincent, China, Dan
and Simon, Dave (the Alpine 1s).
Sincerely - from the rookie clan.

Notices

20% discount – A Long Cold Paddle – Craig Potton Publishing

A Long Cold Paddle by Tara Mulvany is on special with 20% discount until the end of the year. Please log in online for member rates:

<https://alpineclub.org.nz/news/2014/craig-potton-publishing/a-long-cold-paddle/discount>

FMC Youth and Young Adult Scholarship Scheme

Financial assistance to contribute towards costs of a multiday expedition is now available – applications close 12th September. For more information on how to apply go to:

<http://www.fmc.org.nz/scholarship/>

Wanted : New Zealand Alpine Journal 2008

If you have a spare copy of the 2008 Alpine Journal please contact Tom Hu on:

Email: tomyuhu@gmail.com

Home: 03 3433 887

Text: 0226 589 688.

NZAC Alpine Journals

All the available spare past NZAC Journals, as well as the contents pages of all our Journals have now been uploaded into the club's online shop:

<https://alpineclub.org.nz/shop/33?category=33>

The contents pages can be used to find articles for research purposes. To celebrate finally getting this job done, the Journals are currently on sale. There are limited copies only of some issues and please note that these are mostly all second-hand, so conditions vary considerably.

Whangaehu 50 Years Celebration and Re-Opening with Peter Hillary

This event is the highlight of the 2014 Alpine Central calendar.

Our club hut was originally opened fifty years ago by Sir Edmund Hillary. This year we celebrate the complete renovation of the hut with a re-opening ceremony with Peter Hillary.

We are meeting at the Tukino lodge on the evening of Friday 5th September or the next morning where we will make our way up to the hut for around midday. We'll officially re-open the hut with a chance to have a look around and explore this fantastic site.

Following this, it's back to the lodge for a celebratory mid-winter roast dinner - Dress code "Black-ish tie" (those details we leave to your imagination).

Cost \$105 per person

Includes: all meals (cooked breakfasts, prepare it yourself lunches and mid-winter roast and drinks on Saturday evening, 2 nights' accommodation.

If required transportation is available from the 2 wheel drive car park at an extra \$20.00 each way.

For more information or to register your interest, contact Michael Greer chairperson@alpinecentral.org.nz

Otago Polytechnic - Avalanche Safety Stage 1 course - 20-26 September.

This course will be directed by Peter Bilous, NZMGA Ski Guide and past ski patroller at Treble Cone. Course fee is \$1950 which includes transport to and from Cardrona. Visit www.avalanche.ac.nz for more info or phone Barbara Emmitt at 0800 765 9276 to enrol.

Rock Deluxe North guidebook launch

The Rock Deluxe North guidebook launch is happening next week - Thursday 4 September at Hangdog climbing gym, 6.30pm.

Come along for a slideshow, presentation and fun top-rope comp. The guide will be on sale at a special rate on the night (JP might even sign your copy!).

We've also got some fancy swag from Bivouac to give away for the best-dressed and spot prizes.

Wellington Section 2013/14 contacts list

We are always thankful for volunteers and members stepping forward to help the section run smoothly. If you'd like to learn more about how you could get involved, please email us at wellington@alpineclub.org.nz

Position	Name	Email alias*	Contact
Chairperson	Dan Pringle	chairperson	027 768-2185
Vice Chair	Vincent Zintzen	vicechair	
Secretary	Julian Davidson	secretary or CM2	
Treasurer	Adam Newberry	treasurer	
National Rep	Dan Pringle		
Patron	John Nankervis		
Trips	Vacant	Trips	
Other Committee Members	Simon Williamson		
	John Yu		
	Sharran Came		
Other Roles:			
Gear	vacant	gear	
Personal Locator Beacons	vacant	PLB	
Instruction Coordinator	vacant		
Instruction - AIC	vacant		
Instruction - Rock	vacant		
Library	Joke Meerkens	library	
Newsletter Editor	Carolyn Ellis		Kaz1963@gmail.com
Rock Drill Overseer	Kristen Foley	drill or KF	
Website	John Yu	webmaster	
* Email address is: alias@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz eg. secretary@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz			
Any membership, Distaghil Sar Fund, or general queries should be directed to the secretary			
Any media queries should be directed to:			
03 3777 595	National Executive Officer	Sam Newton	sam@alpineclub.org.nz



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